A Heart-Warming Shift: When Fathers Showed Up at the Anganwadi Habba

As a communication professional, I've had the privilege of attending countless events across Makkala Jagriti's programs. Among them, one of the most vibrant and recurring celebrations in our Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) program is the *Anganwadi Habba*. Over the years, I've genuinely lost count of how many Habbas I've been part of, but the energy, colour, and joy they bring never fade.

A Habba is always a lively, bustling space. You'll find groups of young children exploring with bright curiosity, mothers exchanging stories, and Anganwadi teachers proudly showcasing learning materials and activity stations. The air is filled with laughter, chatter, and the warmth that only a community of women and children can create. In many ways, it has always been a women-led event, not just in facilitation, but in attendance and engagement as well.

But today's Habba was different! Beautifully different.

For the first time, I saw a remarkable number of men, fathers, participating with genuine enthusiasm. They were deeply involved. I watched fathers walk hand in hand with their children from one station to the next, listening carefully as teachers explained learning domains, asking thoughtful questions, and encouraging their little ones to try every activity.

It was a heart-warming sight: children perched on their dads' shoulders, pointing excitedly at toys and charts; fathers prompting their children to attempt a puzzle; and even pairs of father and child sitting together, colouring or giggling as they played a giant snakes and ladders game spread across the ground.

How wonderful is that?

In conversations about early childhood and parenting, mothers most often fill the room, attending meetings, asking questions, following up on developmental milestones, and being the primary caregivers in almost every sense. Their dedication is unquestionable. But seeing fathers step into that space today filled my heart in a way I didn't expect.

Because every child deserves *both* parents showing up for them.

Why Fathers Matter in Early Childhood Development

While mothers are traditionally viewed as the primary nurturers, research across the world shows that fathers have a profound impact on early childhood development, sometimes in ways we underestimate:

1. Fathers influence cognitive development.
Children with engaged fathers often display stronger problem-solving skills, better language development, and improved academic readiness.

2. Fathers contribute to emotional security.
A responsive father figure helps children feel safe, confident, and supported, shaping how they build relationships later in life.

3. Fathers introduce diverse learning experiences.
Every parent brings a unique style of play, communication, and interaction. When fathers participate, children experience richer, more varied stimulation, crucial in the early years.

4. Shared parenting strengthens families.
When fathers share responsibility, mothers feel supported, stress is reduced, and the home becomes a more nurturing environment for the child.

Today's Habba wasn't just an event; it was a glimpse into a changing narrative, one where fathers are stepping in, showing up, and shaping their child's earliest experiences with love, curiosity, and pride.

And for me, witnessing that shift was nothing short of beautiful.